

EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM

Week 3

Pulse Diagnosis · Pulse Qualities · Seasonal Pulses

Class: Friday July 25, 2026 · 9AM-1PM

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TCM for Ballroom Dancers | Dance Medicine Specialty

REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE JULY 25

- **FCM Chapter 25** — Maciocia: Normal pulse, 28 pulse qualities, clinical groupings
- **CAM Chapter 13** — Cheng Xinnong: Pulse diagnosis method & qualities
- **Handbook of Contemporary Pulse Diagnosis** — Leon Hammer (reference)

Week 3 Focus: 28 Pulse Qualities · Normal Pulse (胃神根) · Seasonal Pulses · Pulse Combinations · Six Climatic Qi Pulses

温故知新

PULSE POSITIONS — 寸關尺 · Both Hands

Hand			
LEFT	Heart / Pericardium	Liver / Gallbladder	Kidney Yin / Bladder
	Heart side Small Intestine (deep) · Upper Jiao	Middle Jiao	Lower Jiao (L)
RIGHT	Lung / Large Intestine	Spleen / Stomach	Kidney Yang / Bladder
	Lung side Chest · Upper Jiao	Middle Jiao	Lower Jiao (R) · Ming Men

Depth: Superficial = Yang/Exterior · Middle = Blood/SP-ST · Deep = Yin/Interior/KD · **Three positions × Three depths = 9 positions**

NORMAL PULSE — 胃 Wèi · 神 Shén · 根 Gēn

胃 Wèi Stomach-Qi	Flowing, gentle, harmonious — unhurried	Digestive function intact; always present in the living
神 Shén Spirit	Soft but with strength; regular; alive	Vitality of the Mind — good spirit = good prognosis
根 Gēn Root	Clearly felt deep at Chi (rear position)	Kidney Essence intact — constitutional root

NORMAL PULSE COMPONENTS

Rate	4 beats per breath · 60–80 bpm
Rhythm	Regular — no pauses or irregularities
Width	Moderate — not too thin or wide
Depth	Strongest at middle depth
Strength	Forceful with even pressure; not too strong/weak
Shape	Smooth, even, comes and goes easily

6-STEP PULSE READING SEQUENCE

① Feel pulse as a whole
② Check Spirit · Stomach-Qi · Root
③ Three levels & three positions
④ Strength of the pulse
⑤ Overall quality (if one exists)
⑥ Individual position quality

Factors affecting pulse: Time of day · Emotions/activity · Medications · Constitution · Season

Pulse (CN/ Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Group / Key Note
DEPTH			
Floating 浮 Fú Mài	Distinct at superficial; fades slightly at deep — like wood floating on water	Invasion of external Wind; Yin deficiency (interior)	Combos: +Tight=Wind-Cold; +Rapid=Wind-Heat; +Empty=Yin def
Deep/Submerged 沉 Chén Mài	Only felt with heavy pressure, near bone	Interior patterns; Yang deficiency; organ-level issues	+Weak=Yang def; +Wiry=Blood stasis; +Rapid=interior Heat
Hidden 伏 Fú Mài	Press hard to bone — barely perceptible	Severe Yang deficiency; extreme cold obstruction; syncope	+Full=Qi/Blood stagnation; +Empty=severe Yang def
RATE			
Slow 遲 Chí Mài	<3 beats/breath (~40-60 bpm)	Cold pattern; Empty-Cold (Slow+Weak); Full-Cold (Slow+Full)	+Deep=interior Cold; +Slippery=Cold-Phlegm
Moderate 緩 Huǎn Mài	4 beats/breath; even, relaxed, slightly slow	Normal (if regular); Dampness; Spleen deficiency	Normal quality when relaxed; Dampness if sluggish
Rapid 數 Shuò Mài	>5 beats/breath (~90-120 bpm)	Heat pattern; Full-Heat (Rapid+Full); Empty-Heat (Rapid+Empty)	+Floating=Wind-Heat; +Wiry=LV-Fire; +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat
Hurried/Racing 疾 Jí Mài	>7 beats/breath (140-180 bpm) — extreme rapid	Fire exhausting Yin; extreme Heat	+Floating=severe Empty-Heat
STRENGTH			
Full/Overflowing 洪 Hóng Mài	Wide, forceful — rises strongly, fades gently. Like ocean waves	Full-Heat; Empty-Heat (Overflowing+Empty)	+Floating=Wind-Heat intense; +Slippery=Phlegm-Heat
Empty/Deficient 虛 Xū Mài	Wide but forceless at all three positions; sense of emptiness	Qi deficiency; general deficiency	+Floating=Qi/Blood def; +Slow=Yang def
Minute/Faint 微 Wēi Mài	Extremely thin and forceless; seems to come and go	Severe deficiency of Qi and Blood; near-collapse	+Rapid=Yin def+Empty-Heat; +Choppy=Blood exhaustion
Weak/Frail 弱 Ruò Mài	Forceless, deep, thin — only felt at deep depth	Yang deficiency; Blood deficiency	+Choppy=Blood def; +Slow=Yang def
SHAPE / WIDTH			
Wiry 弦 Xián Mài	Taut, long, forceful — like a guitar string	Liver disharmony; Pain; Phlegm; Spring (seasonal)	+Rapid=LV-Fire; +Slow=Cold in LV channel; +Tight=Blood stasis
Tight 緊 Jǐn Mài	Tense, like a twisted rope — bounces side to side	Cold patterns; Pain; Food retention	+Floating=exterior Cold; +Deep=interior Cold
Slippery 滑 Huá Mài	Smooth, rounded, quick — like a pearl rolling on a plate	Phlegm; Dampness; Food retention; Pregnancy	+Rapid=Damp-Heat/Phlegm-Heat; +Slow=Damp-Cold
Choppy/Rough 澀 Sè Mài	Rough, uneven — like scraping bamboo	Blood stasis; Blood deficiency; Yin deficiency	+Wiry=Blood stasis; +Weak=Blood def
Long 長 Cháng Mài	Extends beyond Cun and Chi positions	Heat patterns; Liver excess	+Rapid=internal Heat; +Wiry=LV disharmony
Short 短 Duǎn Mài	Cannot be felt in all three positions	Qi deficiency; Qi stagnation	+Choppy=Blood stasis + Qi def
Hollow 芤 Kōu Mài	Wide, soft; hollow in center — like a scallion stalk	Hemorrhage; forthcoming hemorrhage (Hollow+Rapid); Yin def	+Rapid=Yin def+Empty-Heat or hemorrhage
Soggy 濡 Rú Mài	Superficial, thin, forceless; weakens with pressure	Dampness; Qi/Blood deficiency	+Slow=Damp-Cold; +Rapid=Damp-Heat

Pulse (CN/ Pinyin)	How It Feels	Clinical Indication	Group / Key Note
Firm/Confined 牢 Láo Mài	Deep, taut, long, wide, forceful — only at deep depth	Blood stasis; Interior Cold; Pain	+Tight=internal Cold; +Slow=Cold+Blood stasis
Scattered 散 Sàn Mài	Wide, superficial, forceless, irregular — disappears on pressure	Collapse of Original Qi; critical condition	Serious sign — loss of Kidney foundation
RHYTHM (IRREGULAR)			
Hasty 促 Cù Mài	Rapid with irregular stops — urgently restless	Severe Heat; Heart-Qi deficiency; Heart-Fire	+Overflowing=HT-ST Heat; +Wiry=LV/HT Fire
Intermittent 代 Dài Mài	Regular pauses at fixed intervals	Serious internal organ disease; Heart problem (Western)	Most serious irregular pulse — organ failure sign
Knotted 結 Jié Mài	Slow with irregular stops	Cold obstructing; Qi stagnation; Phlegm; Blood stasis	Opposite of Hasty (Hasty=rapid+stops; Knotted=slow+stops)

Spring 春	Wiry 弦 Xián <i>Yang arising</i>	Slightly tense, taut — if too tense = Tight pulse (pathology)	Yang Qi wants to arise but cold Yin obstructs → tension. Wiry in spring = NORMAL; too wiry or wiry outside spring → Liver disharmony	Feb 4 - May 4
Summer 夏	Flooding 洪 Hóng <i>Full Yang</i>	Wide, forceful, rises strongly — fades gently like ocean waves	Yang Qi completely uninhibited — rises & spreads outward. Flooding in summer = NORMAL; don't call excess without other signs	May 5 - Aug 6
Autumn 秋	Hair-like 毛 Máo <i>Yin arising</i>	Light, floating, delicate — "like elm pods falling through the air" (Su Wen); like a hair on skin surface	Yang Qi desiring to be restrained & collected. Light and empty = NORMAL in autumn	Aug 7 - Nov 6
Winter 冬	Stone-like 石 Shí <i>Yang stored</i>	Sinks deep — like a stone. Only felt at deep depth. Harder to feel = NORMAL	Yang Qi gathered and stored — when Yang retracts, pulse sinks. Students always struggle in winter — this is why	Nov 7 - Feb 3

SIX CLIMATIC QI → PULSE (From Slides)		SHANG HAN LUN STAGE PULSES	
Wind 風	Floating	Taiyang 太陽	Floating
Cold 寒	Tight, contracted, deep	Yangming 陽明	Flooding or Long
Summer-Heat 暑	Floating, Vacuous	Shaoyang 少陽	Wiry
Dampness 濕	Soggy, Slippery	Taiyin 太陰	Moderate (middle depth)
Dryness 燥	Short, Hasty, Rough	Shaoyin 少陰	Faint and Thin
Fire/Heat 火	Restless, Rapid	Jueyin 厥陰	Thin, tendency to expire

Combination	Clinical Meaning
Floating + Rapid	Wind-Heat invasion
Floating + Tight	Wind-Cold invasion
Floating + Empty	Yin deficiency (interior — NOT exterior)
Deep + Slow	Interior Cold
Deep + Rapid	Interior Heat
Rapid + Full	Full-Heat (Excess Yang)
Rapid + Empty	Empty-Heat (Yin deficiency)
Wiry + Rapid	Liver-Fire
Slippery + Rapid	Phlegm-Heat or Damp-Heat
Choppy + Wiry	Blood stasis
Overflowing + Summer	Normal seasonal (do NOT call excess)
Wiry + Spring	Normal seasonal (Liver only if too wiry or off-season)

PATTERN NAME	WEEK / QUIZ
DISEASE CATEGORY	ORGAN SYSTEM
ETIOLOGY	DATE

CLINICAL ESSENTIALS · TONGUE · PULSE · TREATMENT PRINCIPLE

TONGUE 舌診 · COLOR / COAT / SHAPE	CLINICAL ESSENTIALS

PULSE 脈診 · CUN · GUAN · CHI

Wrist	CUN 寸	GUAN 關	CHI 尺
L			
R			

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE

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